

HOW TO WRITE AN ACADEMIC PAPER: A GUIDEBOOK, EDITION 1



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How to Write an Academic Paper: A
Guidebook, edition 1

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Preface

How it starts....

So, you are in college and one of your teachers has just assigned an essay. What do they want, really, and where should you begin? How can you get through this assignment as painlessly as possible? How do you stay in control of the task and not let the task take control of you? What is an essay in the first place? What does my teacher expect?

These are several possible questions that could be running through your mind as you look into the abyss of your professor's instructions, feeling the dread that comes with a vision of yourself in the future, sitting down, frantic, trying to write a paper, looking through books, handouts, and other class-related materials periodically scribbling nonsense in desperation.

Why I wrote this book

This guidebook hopes to prevent that from happening. If you follow the steps laid out here one by one, this companion handbook shall endeavor to help you through the experience of writing an essay, starting the moment you get the prompt all the way through finishing a draft in progress.

Or, perhaps you are a liberal arts teacher who does not have time to teach composition and yet wants to do what they can to help students who have not taken a composition class, or who maybe did not get everything they needed from the comp. class they did take, write the paper your are expecting to read at the level you teach at.

Ultimately, I want to break things down as simply as possible and provide a method that allows students to get through the academic writing process as painlessly as possible while also staying in control as much as they can.

Composition Commandments

Before we begin...

Please consider the list of "commandments" provided below. I advise you to come back to this list repeatedly until everything makes sense and you need no more reminders. Let's consider these the Commandments of College Essays.

Commandments

1. Make sure you **understand what the prompt is asking** and all the instructions on the prompt. Work with a tutor or your instructor if you need clarification on the prompt. You will likely need to read the prompt several times to fully understand all the instructions. The prompt is what you are graded on. It should pose a specific question or task that you are supposed to answer in the essay. For example, let's say the question on the prompt is "What is the role and limitations of the U.S. government in fighting climate change?" You might think, "Oh, this essay is just about climate change." No. If you plan to simply write an essay about climate change or an essay about why we should take action against it, you are already fucking up. The specific question is "what is the role and limitations of government in fighting climate change". Your paper should examine what the government should do and simply cannot do to fight climate change, in your opinion.
2. The college essay should **explain your ideas**, not report back on things that have happened, background information, histories, etc. Yes, you can use this expository information to explain your ideas so long as the expository information is not the focus of the essay. The focus of the essay should be on your ideas and opinions related to what is asked on the prompt. Each body paragraph should explain one idea or opinion you have that also answers the question or task on the prompt. I will explain this in more detail later.
3. The **ideas you write about** will likely **have to be based on existing materials** provided by your instructor or materials you found doing your own research. You might instinctively have a million ideas about the role and limitations of government in fighting climate change but if they are not supported by materials provided or found from research, then it will be difficult to include them in your paper.
4. **Taking a College Composition class** will help you write papers for all classes that require them. Unless your College Composition teacher is completely checked out or is a total hippie, you should learn how to structure an "argumentative essay" and this structure will be applicable to other classes in which essay writing is required. Don't put off taking this class even though it is an English class and most of us would rather take anything but.
5. Make sure you **understand the terminology used** in your College Composition class related to essay writing. Terms often used include "thesis statement", "topic sentence", "analysis", "claims", "evidence" and more. Some of the terms are used interchangeably. Whatever terms your teacher prefers, understanding the terminology and how it applies to college essays will give you a higher level of control in your writing. You will have a better understanding of what you need to fix, add, take out, change, etc. if you understand the role and purpose of different elements of your essay as defined by the terminology associated with them. In this preface I have provided a glossary that I hope is helpful in acquainting you with these terms.
6. Keep in mind that virtually **every sentence in your academic writing should have a role or purpose** and therefore, all content in your essay will have some kind of terminology attached to it such as the ones mentioned above: "thesis statement", "topic sentence", "background information", "signal phrase", "analysis", etc. This is why understanding the terminology is so important. If asked by your teacher "what is this sentence doing?" you should be able to answer using the proper terminology i.e. "that is my thesis statement" or "that is part of my analysis" or "that is some background information". In this guide, I have provided a glossary of terms related to college essays that I hope is helpful.

Don't feel...

Like you have to memorize or understand these Commandments right now. Continue to come back to them. The more you work on your essay and move through this guidebook, the more they will make sense.

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Glossary of Terms used Related to Academic Papers and Essays

Context

There are specific terms that go along with writing academic papers. Understanding these terms will help you understand what your teacher is asking for as well as how to interpret any advice you receive from tutors as well as this guidebook. Remember, all content in our papers has a purpose. These terms often signify that purpose. Learning the terms will give you control. Please learn the terminology as best you can. Be patient, review it often, and do your best to understand it. I promise it will help immensely if you do.

Glossary

Prompt—A handout provided by your teacher that offers a question you must answer in the essay and details the criteria that is expected in the final draft of your essay.

Subject—What the essay is about in general. Consider the question posed on your teacher's prompt.

Thesis Statement—The student's overall argument or stance regarding the essay's subject (usually written as the last sentence(s) of the introduction paragraph).

Points—Ideas or opinions of the student that they choose to write about which will support the validity of their thesis. Each point is the focus of its own body paragraph. Points are also sometimes called "claims" or "topics"

Body Paragraphs—every paragraph after the introduction and before the conclusion in which a point is introduced, examples and evidence are provided, and analysis is used to explain how the point being made proves the thesis is true.

Topic Sentence—the first sentence of a body paragraph in which the point of the paragraph is clearly introduced.

Context/Background Information—information given after the topic sentence that clarifies the point being made, defines needed terms, and/or provides information about the source of evidence to be provided which can also include background on the author(s) of the source.

Signal phrase—a phrase coming directly before a quote or delivery of some information that let's the reader know evidence from an outside source is about to be provided and possibly where it is coming from.

Examples/Evidence—information, usually from outside sources, that shows the point put forth in a topic sentence is based on something the student read, heard, watched, or otherwise absorbed.

In-text Citations—parenthetical information following a quote or other evidence that will help the reader find the source on the essay's works cited page.

Analysis—explanation at the end of each body paragraph as to how the point being made proves the thesis is valid.

Introduction Paragraph—the opening paragraph of the essay in which the subject is introduced, sources of information can be provided, and the thesis is often delivered, usually as the last sentence.

Conclusion Paragraph—the final paragraph of the essay in which a sense of closure is provided by the student.

Heading—information in the top left corner of the essay's first page (student's name, instructor's name, course name, due date). The heading is situated within the margins of the essay on page one of the essay.

Header—information in the top right corner on every page of the essay (student's last name and correct page number). Headers are situated above the margins of the essay on every page.

Works cited—a page that comes after the essay that lists sources used for evidence in the essay.

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Chapter 1: Understand the Prompt, Find Evidence, Develop Ideas

[1.1: Understand the Prompt](#)

[1.2: Find Evidence and Develop Ideas to Write About in Your Paper](#)

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1.1: Understand the Prompt

The first step in writing your essay is to resist the urge to write your essay. This is an exercise in control and control you will need to compose a successful paper.

The first step in writing your essay is to make sure you understand the prompt fully and completely.

Understanding the essay prompt is paramount to your success in writing an essay. Nothing upsets me more than when a student does not follow the specific instructions I provided on an essay prompt.

The prompt should ask a specific question or give a specific task that “prompts” you to think about an issue in a way that promotes the development of your own opinions about said issue. Using the example below let’s say the question or task on the prompt is to....

- “Write an essay in which you discuss the role and/or limitations of the U.S. government in fighting climate change.”

Think Carefully

This is a task that requires you to think about what you believe the government can do about climate change and what the limitations of the government are in solving the problem. Different people will have different opinions about what is and is not possible for the government to solve the problem.

Also, notice that this is a specific question related to climate change. The task is not to simply “write an essay on climate change” or “why we should take action” or “what the dangers are” or “if climate change is real”. None of these approaches would answer the specific question posed by your teacher.

Always make sure you fully understand the question or task and its specifics. If you write an essay that does not answer the specific question or task, you will not score well on your final submission. If needed, work with a tutor or your professor to make sure you fully understand the question or task given on the prompt.

Additionally, the prompt could have other criteria listed about what the essay requires and how it will be graded. These requirements can vary depending on your teacher, although they will likely include information about a thesis statement, formatting, length, when the paper is due, if a counterargument is required, where the sources of your supporting evidence should come from, among other things.

After you have a full understanding of the task or question on the prompt, make sure you are clear on the additional criteria as well. Again, work with a tutor or your instructor if needed. Clarity on what is asked for on the prompt is the first step to writing a successful paper. Keep in mind that much of the criteria is something you can come back to, although the question or task is important to understand before getting too far along in your work. If you finish a draft of your essay and then realize you misunderstood the question or task on the prompt, you might have to start all over from the beginning.

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1.2: Find Evidence and Develop Ideas to Write About in Your Paper

I understand the prompt, now what?

Continue resisting the urge to write your essay. We are going to carefully plan what to write about first.

With an understanding of the prompt, the task now becomes thinking of things to write about. Remember, your writing should focus on your opinions related to the question or task provided on the prompt. Each idea or point you want to make will be the focus of its own “body paragraph”. Each body paragraph will introduce an idea or point you want to make that answers what is asked on the essay prompt. We will discuss this in more detail later.

You Might Feel...

I know you might feel a strong urge to dive head first into a draft of your paper. As I have cautioned, please resist this impulse. Do not try to write the essay without careful planning first. Additionally, resist the urge to feel like you have to start by writing an introduction and/or a thesis statement. Trust me, those things can (and should) come later.

Right Now...

What to understand now is that your essay needs to focus on your own ideas and the ideas you decide to write about must also be based on materials provided by our teacher or materials found using your own research. Take a breath. Ground yourself. Be intentional.

At this level, we are not writing reports. We are instead trying to explain our own ideas and opinions and those ideas and opinions must be based on materials we have absorbed, not ideas that came to us out of thin air or are based on what we think we already know. Additionally, don't start writing your ideas in detail right away. Writing about ideas requires focus. Your teacher will expect you to write about one idea at a time. Resist the urge to dive in head first. Take the time to think, keep notes, and plan.

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1.3: Getting Ideas

Where to Get Ideas?

There are several ways to try and generate ideas to explain in your paper. You can do some form of pre-writing, including free-writing, listing, word clouding, etc. These practices might help you come up with ideas and opinions you decide you want to explain in your paper. With these ideas written down, the next move would be to find evidence that supports them. This is a completely viable method and works in a linear way; that is, in your paper, the idea is mentioned first and the evidence comes after. The drawback here is that it can be time-consuming to find evidence that supports your ideas and possibly even fruitless (what if you don't find any evidence to support the ideas you wrote down?).

Another method, the method I recommend to my students, is to look through the materials that your instructor provided or that you found in your research and find content that gives you ideas and opinions that also answer the question or task provided on the essay prompt. By following this method, you can write down both the ideas and opinions you want to explain along with the evidence that supports those ideas and opinions at the same time. Doing this gives you the foundation for your body paragraphs (more on that later).

Develop Ideas Based on Materials

I realize this might be easier said than done. To break it down step by step, consider looking at the materials you have to draw evidence from for your paper. Perhaps it's more encouraging, more useful to simply mark, underline, or copy down the information that sticks out to you and then take some time to reflect on why it stuck out and what you believe the information is saying to you. For example, let's say I am reading an article my teacher provided for the essay, and I come across this passage:

- *"Since becoming one of the first countries to implement a national carbon tax in 1991, Sweden has successfully lowered its greenhouse gas emissions by 27 percent. And although critics believed the tax would stunt the economy, Sweden's gross domestic product has since doubled. Today, more than thirty countries have implemented a national carbon tax, including Argentina, Canada, Japan, Singapore, and Ukraine."*

To me, this passage offers support for a potential idea about what the government can do to try and prevent climate change. With this evidence highlighted or copied down in my notes, I can come back to it and think about what it says to me regarding what government can do to combat climate change. I can also take time to think about it the very moment that I discovered it in the reading.

The quote is telling me that Sweden implemented a carbon tax in 1991 and since then has lowered its greenhouse gas emissions by 27 percent. This information makes me think that the government can combat climate change by implementing taxes on carbon and other products and byproducts that have been linked to the increase in global warming. Therefore, I might come up with a point or idea such as:

- *"One thing the government can do to fight climate change is implement a carbon tax."*

This idea can be the focus of a part of my paper (one of my body paragraphs) and the quote above which led me to develop this idea would be the supporting evidence in that same paragraph. Now, I have developed an idea at the same time that I captured evidence to support it. I don't have to go looking for evidence to support my idea. This is the process which I recommend students use to develop ideas.

1. Find evidence from the readings and materials that you can use in your paper.
2. Develop ideas based on each piece of evidence you found.
3. When you have a collection of ideas each paired with a piece of evidence, we can move on to the next step.

Note...

You might be thinking that the idea above is too obvious and not original. The evidence is clear and the point I derived from it is obvious. Consider that some people might read that passage and feel it is not compelling enough. It is unfair to compare Sweden and the U.S. and what works for them may not work for us. It can also be a coincidence that they lowered their emissions since the implementation of the tax and that the tax really had nothing to do with their lowered emissions.

I say this to say, don't stop yourself from making note of potentially useful information for the essay and don't stop yourself from generating ideas. What seems obvious to you is not necessarily obvious to another person and each piece of evidence you find for your paper can be interpreted in a variety of ways. Your interpretation of the materials you absorb is what your teacher wants to see in your essays. Many people might develop the same idea as you and many might not. Your ideas don't have to be 100% original. They just have to be your interpretations of information that you have found.

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1.4: Chapter Recap

First Steps

In my opinion, these are the best first steps in writing your essay.

- Understand the prompt completely (work with your instructor or a tutor for clarity if needed).
- Resist the urge to dive in to a draft of your essay. Plan things out first.
- Absorb the materials provided by your instructor or collected in your research carefully (understand what they are and the information they convey).
- Find content in those materials that you believe answers the question posed on the prompt (make sure it is easy to recall the information when needed).
- Develop ideas and opinions based on the content you found that you can write about in different parts (body paragraphs) of your essay.
- In your paper, each idea you develop will be supported by one or two pieces of evidence (content found in the materials).
- Each idea will be the focus of its own “body paragraph” (more on this later).

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Chapter 2: Understand "Body Paragraphs" and Their Structure

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2.1: Body Paragraphs

Ok, I have ideas and evidence, now what?

As mentioned, the ideas you develop and the content that supports those ideas will be the basis for your essay's "body paragraphs". At this stage, those ideas and the evidence that supports them might seem minor. Trust me, they will develop. Having them pinned down is a major advantage in your essay writing process.

What do you mean by "body paragraphs"?

Remember, writing papers in college is all about explaining your ideas. Each idea should be explained in its own paragraph of writing. We call these paragraphs "body paragraphs". Each idea you have written down from the previous step (along with its corresponding evidence) can be developed into one body paragraph.

To put it more simply: 1 idea = 1 body paragraph

Body paragraphs will make up the bulk of your essay. Consider that your essay will have only one introduction paragraph at the beginning and one conclusion paragraph at the end. Everything in between will be a body paragraph. Also note that you have some freedom to write your introduction and conclusion paragraphs as you see fit. Intros and conclusions do not require an explanation of ideas or analysis of evidence. They simply work to introduce and conclude your essay.

Why focus on body paragraphs?

Body paragraphs require a heightened level of focus and organization. They are the paragraphs in which you explain your ideas and analyze the evidence you use to support those ideas. This is why I prioritize pinning them down early on in the process.

What do I need to know about body paragraphs now?

First, understand that each body paragraph should focus on only one point at a time. As mentioned, the ideas you have written down from the previous stage each can be the basis for their own body paragraph.

To write a body paragraph, you need to understand that there are three main parts. Here are the three main parts listed in the order they will appear in your body paragraphs.

1. A topic sentence that shares one of your ideas.
2. The example or piece of evidence found in your materials that corresponds to that idea.
3. Analysis that explains how the example or evidence provided supports the point you made in your topic sentence and how the point you are making in the paragraph supports your thesis statement.

Note

If you did indeed look over materials and come up with ideas based on those materials that answer what is asked on the prompt, then you should have the first two parts for several different body paragraphs.

If you need more clarity, then I hope the next few pages make things more clear.

We will consider analysis and thesis statements later. Right now, let's just focus on ideas and evidence.

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2.2: 3.1-Revisiting Evidence and Ideas

Recap

If you are following the method of finding evidence and writing ideas that I detailed in the previous chapter of this guidebook, then, right now, you should be focused on finding content from your materials, making sure you can access that content easily, thinking about the content, and writing down the ideas the content gives you that also answers the question or task on the essay prompt.

To put it more simply: review materials, note content of interest, develop ideas based on said content.

How the process might look, part 1

For example, let's say after looking through my materials, I found the following seven passages about climate change actions:

- "...cap and trade programs ensure emissions in a city or country do not exceed a designated limit. Today, thirteen U.S. states, China, Mexico, and every country in the European Union have implemented cap and trade systems...In 2013, California launched one of the United States' first cap and trade programs. As a result, the state's emissions fell by 10 percent between 2013 and 2018."=
- "To decrease emissions, around two-thirds of U.S. states have implemented clean energy standards...In 1999, Texas instituted a clean energy standard to source ten thousand megawatts of electricity from renewable energy... This standard helped kick start growth in the state's renewable energy sector... Today, Texas generates around 25 percent of its electricity from renewable sources."
- "Since becoming one of the first countries to implement a national carbon tax in 1991, Sweden has successfully lowered its greenhouse gas emissions by 27 percent. And although critics believed the tax would stunt the economy, Sweden's gross domestic product has since doubled. Today, more than thirty countries have implemented a national carbon tax, including Argentina, Canada, Japan, Singapore, and Ukraine."
- "When anti-American industry and energy policies outsource production and jobs to China, the same things will be made, but under China's environmental standards, or lack thereof, with more pollution.... Entirely eliminating fossil fuels and returning our economies to the stone age does nothing if you only force production to pack up and move to a country with worse environmental standards."
- "If the whole country went carbon-neutral tomorrow, the standard United Nations climate model shows the difference by the end of the century would be a barely noticeable reduction in temperature of 0.3 degree[s] Fahrenheit. This is because the U.S. will make up an ever-smaller share of emissions as the populations of China, India and Africa grow and get richer.... A realistic climate solution would instead focus on innovation to bring down the price of cleaner energy to one both American and Indian voters are willing to pay."
- "The answer is that you'd want to reshore as much American manufacturing as possible and you'd want to produce as much energy as possible in the United States of America because we're the cleanest economy in the entire world.... What have [the Biden administration's] policies actually led to? More energy production in China, more manufacturing overseas, more doing business in some of the dirtiest parts of the entire world.... So if we actually care about getting cleaner air and cleaner water, the best thing to do is to double down and invest in American workers and the American people."
- "The whole point of cap and trade is to hike the price of electricity and gas so that Americans will use less. These higher prices will show up not just in electricity bills or at the gas station but in every manufactured good, from food to cars. Consumers will cut back on spending, which in turn will cut back on production, which results in fewer jobs created or higher unemployment."

Understand the Value of this Content

Above, I have found seven separate passages, some of which answer what the government is capable of and others that address the limitations of government in fighting climate change. With these passages accessible in my notes, I can think about what they are telling me and, in turn, develop ideas that can be the focus of body paragraphs in my essay. My ideas will answer the task that has been provided on the prompt, and I won't have to go looking for any supporting evidence since I found the supporting evidence first and then developed ideas based on each piece of evidence I found. In order to develop ideas based on this content, I will look closely at each passage and consider what it is telling me. As an exercise, why don't you take some time to look at the above information and see if you can develop ideas based on what you think the information is telling you. Or, take some time to look over the materials you have for your paper. What information sticks out as evidence that can be used?

Part Two of This Process

Below are ideas I developed that correspond to each piece of evidence above in the order they are listed. Remember, each idea will be the focus of its own body paragraph, and each piece of evidence will support its corresponding idea in the body paragraph. I found seven passages, as shared above. Each passage gave me an idea or opinion resulting in seven different ideas I can write about in my paper. The idea will be articulated as the "topic sentence" for the paragraph. It will be the first sentence in the paragraph. The evidence will follow shortly after the topic sentence. Look at each idea below and notice how it corresponds to a piece of evidence above. For example, notice how the first idea in the list below corresponds to the first piece of evidence in the list above.

Ideas aka Points aka Topic Sentences based on the above quotes:

- The government can implement cap and trade policies to lower emissions and promote clean energy.
- The implementation of clean energy standards can promote the proliferation of clean energy.
- By implementing a carbon tax, the government can help to lower greenhouse gas emissions.
- When the government imposes clean energy policies, the result is an outsourcing of jobs to countries like China who have no energy standards and are worse polluters.
- Our best efforts to transition to clean energy will not make a difference in the larger context of emissions around the entire world.
- The U.S. already has the highest standards in the world and the government can't do more than what is being done already.
- Efforts such as cap and trade are counterproductive as they end up hurting the average American.

Note

Depending on how long my paper is supposed to be (a requirement that should be listed on the essay prompt) and how firm a stance my professor wants me to take (I could write a paper focusing on only what is possible, or only the limitations, or both), I'm confident this is a pretty solid list of diverse ideas and supporting evidence for the paper. Once I decide the ideas I want to write about, the next step will be to organize my ideas in an outline so that my body paragraphs can maintain the level of focus and organization that will be expected.

What's important right now is I have ideas for the paper and each idea has a corresponding example or piece of evidence found in academically appropriate sources.

If you can pin down the points you want to write about with the evidence that supports them, you will be in good shape to move on to the next steps in the development of your essay. Keep in mind, we are still planning at this stage. We are not drafting anything yet.

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2.3: Organize Ideas and Notes Using an Outline

Ok, I see the Value of Evidence and Ideas, now what?

Because our body paragraphs are the most substantial part of our essays and because they require a heightened level of focus and organization, I encourage you to try and organize the notes, ideas, and evidence that will be the basis of each body paragraph using an outline.

Remember, our body paragraphs have three major parts:

- The topic sentence (sometimes called a "point" or a "claim")
- An example or piece of evidence
- Analysis (sometimes called "explanation" or "reasoning")

These three major parts are written out in our body paragraphs in that order. Each of these parts together makes one body paragraph. Therefore, I believe it is useful to outline body paragraphs following that structure before drafting our paper to ensure we are writing with the level of focus and organization that is expected. I personally do not feel that outlining an introduction paragraph or conclusion is a necessary practice.

Consider the template below for outlining your body paragraphs.

Outline Template:

Body Paragraph #1

- Topic sentence—
- Example/Evidence—
- Analysis—

Body Paragraph #2

- Topic sentence—
- Example/Evidence—
- Analysis—

Body Paragraph #3

- Topic sentence—
- Example/Evidence—
- Analysis—

Body Paragraph #4

- Topic sentence—
- Example/Evidence—
- Analysis—

Look!

Notice this template sets you up to write four different body paragraphs, one at a time, just as they will appear in your essay. Also notice that each body paragraph is outlined by its three major parts, each in the order that should appear in the essay. With the outline filled out in detail, writing the essay becomes super manageable.

Note

The template above is for four different body paragraphs. Remember, the number of body paragraphs required will depend on the length of your paper. The longer the paper, the more body paragraphs you will be obliged to write.

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2.4: Filling in Your Outline

Filling it in

Let's look at how we can begin filling in our outline with just our ideas and the corresponding evidence we have from the previous page.

Body Paragraph #1

- **Topic sentence**—"The government can implement cap and trade policies to lower emissions and promote clean energy."
- **Example/Evidence**—"...*cap and trade programs ensure emissions in a city or country do not exceed a designated limit. Today, thirteen U.S. states, China, Mexico, and every country in the European Union have implemented cap and trade systems... In 2013, California launched one of the United States' first cap and trade programs. As a result, the state's emissions fell by 10 percent between 2013 and 2018.*"
- **Analysis**—

Body Paragraph #2

- **Topic sentence**—"The implementation of clean energy standards can promote the proliferation of clean energy."
- **Example/Evidence**—"To decrease emissions, around two-thirds of U.S. states have implemented clean energy standards... *In 1999, Texas instituted a clean energy standard to source ten thousand megawatts of electricity from renewable energy... This standard helped kick start growth in the state's renewable energy sector... Today, Texas generates around 25 percent of its electricity from renewable sources.*"
- **Analysis**—

Body Paragraph #3

- **Topic sentence**—"By implementing a carbon tax, the government can help to lower greenhouse gas emissions."
- **Example/Evidence**—"Since becoming one of the first countries to implement a national carbon tax in 1991, Sweden has successfully lowered its greenhouse gas emissions by 27 percent. And although critics believed the tax would stunt the economy, Sweden's gross domestic product has since doubled. Today, more than thirty countries have implemented a national carbon tax, including Argentina, Canada, Japan, Singapore, and Ukraine."
- **Analysis**—

Note

Notice how using the outline, I can organize what I have in my notes to develop the basis for body paragraphs, which will make up the bulk of my essay. Also, notice how the outline sets me up to focus on one body paragraph at a time. Notice also how I did not fill in the analysis yet. This is because I don't have my analysis yet. I only have my ideas, which become my topic sentences, and my examples/evidence, which is the content that stuck out to me from sources I read, which became the basis for each of my ideas (topic sentences). These two major parts of the body paragraph (topic sentences and examples/evidence) are now organized in a way that reflects how they will appear in my essay.

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2.5: Chapter Recap

Recap

So far, if you have been following along, you should notice that:

- We started this essay by making sure we understand the prompt.
- We looked closely at materials we had or that were provided to us for evidence that stood out to us.
- We developed ideas based on that evidence that also address the task or question posed on the prompt.
- Considering the role and importance of "body paragraphs" in our paper, we organized those ideas and notes into an outline.
- We are planning each body paragraph just a few steps at a time to stay in control.
- If you have currently been assigned an essay, I recommend you start in the same manner that has been articulated so far in this guidebook.
- Please review the process as many times as needed in order to develop confidence!!!

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Chapter 3: The Thesis Statement

- [3.1: What is a Thesis Statement](#)
- [3.2: Developing a Thesis Statement](#)
- [3.3: Multi-tiered aka Multi-pronged Thesis Statements](#)
- [3.4: Chapter Recap](#)

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3.1: What is a Thesis Statement

What is a Thesis Statement?

Let's pause our outlines and body paragraphs for one moment. We will come back to them after this chapter. I can't let too much time go by without bringing up the role and importance of a thesis statement in your essay. You have probably heard the term and read about it on your prompt. I realize I have not covered it yet. This is because I think it is best to focus on the paragraph level ideas you want to write about first.

As mentioned, the essays we write in college should focus on our own ideas. Each body paragraph focuses on explaining one idea at a time. Often, this is referred to as an "argumentative" essay since each idea we write about is on some level debatable. Our thesis statement also reflects our own original idea although instead of being explained in detail in a body paragraph, it is just mentioned. The ideas explained in each body paragraph work to support or validate the thesis statement.

A thesis statement represents the overall argument you want to make in your essay. Note that your teacher will usually expect your thesis statement to be stated explicitly, not implied. Additionally, your thesis statement should be presented as an argument, opinion, position, or stance. Your thesis statement should not be framed as a question or a statement of intent. Most of the time, teachers request the thesis statement to be written as the last sentence of your introduction paragraph. There are cases where a teacher will instruct the thesis be placed in a different part of your paper. Sometimes, a teacher will be ok with an implied thesis statement. It should be clear in the essay prompt what your teacher expects. Most of the time, we write our thesis statements explicitly as the last sentence of an introduction paragraph. Every point or idea we write about in our body paragraphs should work to support our thesis statement unless stated otherwise by the prompt.

For Example

If I had to write an essay on who is the greatest rap artist and why, my thesis or overall argument could be:

- "Tupac Shakur is the greatest rap artist of all time."

Then, I would support that argument one point or idea at a time, each point or idea being explained in its own body paragraph. The focus of those paragraphs might be as follows:

- Tupac was more prolific than any other rap artist.
- Tupac reached a wider audience than any other rap artist.
- Tupac articulated about meaningful issues with more impact than any other rap artist.

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3.2: Developing a Thesis Statement

With this in mind...

You might be wondering why I didn't bring up the thesis statement earlier. That's a fair point. Many teachers and students will begin their essays by trying to think of a thesis statement. The reason I don't work this way is that I feel it is harder to think of a thesis statement and then set off to prove it than it is to decide what you want to write about in each body paragraph and then develop a thesis statement that works as an overall argument which those points/ideas will work to support.

For example...

If I thought of my thesis statement for the hypothetical essay I have been working on in this guidebook first, I would then have to go looking for content that supports it. I have no idea how easy or hard it will be to find that content. I might struggle to find content and then be in a position where I feel stuck. However, if I already know what I want to write about and have evidence that supports it, I can potentially develop a thesis statement that acts as an overall argument to the points and evidence I already have. It does take some thought, but I do believe it is a less resistant path.

Consider this approach in more detail.

Let's say I have decided to write about the points below in my essay:

- The government can implement cap and trade policies to lower emissions and promote clean energy.
- The implementation of clean energy standards can promote the proliferation of clean energy.
- By implementing a carbon tax, the government can help to lower greenhouse gas emissions.

I have evidence that supports each of these points, which gives me a focus for three different body paragraphs (one for each of the above points). What I have not thought of yet is a thesis statement. I know I want to write about the above points. Now, I have to think of an overall argument that answers the question on the essay prompt and that each one of my points will support.

In order to develop...

...a thesis statement that all these points support, I am first going to consider what they all have in common. Before I list what I think they have in common, please take some time to consider what you believe they have in common.

In this case, I see the word "implementing" in all of the points. I also see that each point has to do with a policy that I expect our government to have the power to put in place, given that they have the approval to do so.

Considering that each point is about "implementing" some kind of "policy," I might draft a thesis statement that reads as follows:

- "The U.S. government is able to implement policies that can reduce the impact of climate change on our planet."

Look at that statement carefully and then look at the points above. Do you see how each point clearly supports it and how it can work as the overall argument for our essay?

When I do have my thesis statement ready, I like to write it at the top of my outline as to maintain the standards of organization I have set.

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3.3: Multi-tiered aka Multi-pronged Thesis Statements

Additionally...

There is a way of writing a thesis statement that is perhaps more straightforward. In this method, a student will simply list the points they plan to explain to create their thesis statement. I refer to this method as a “multi-tiered thesis statement” or a “multi-pronged thesis statement” as the thesis statement will have “tiers” or “prongs” that the paper branches off on in the body paragraphs. Here is an example based on the points I used above:

- “The U.S government can implement cap and trade policies, clean energy standards, and a carbon tax to help reduce the impact of climate change on our planet.”

Some of you might be thinking, “Well, that method is way easier, so why don’t I just do that?”

Consider if you have to write a long essay in which there are close to 10 points, at least, that you want to make. Are you going to list them all in your thesis statement? I would encourage you not to as the thesis statement will become clunky and unsophisticated.

What you can do in that situation is look at what your points have in common. Maybe a few of them have one thing in common, a few have a separate thing in common, and a few of the others have their own thing in common. If you can separate each point into categories (I recommend no more than three), then you can use a multi-tiered thesis to list each of these larger categories and connect the points in your body paragraphs back to the category they belong to. For example, if my categories were “policies, taxes, and standards,” then I could write multiple body paragraphs about policies, multiple about standards, and multiple about taxes and still maintain a tight multi-tiered thesis statement that does not preview each specific point but rather a few categories my individual points will belong to.

Note:

When you have a thesis statement drafted, I encourage you to include it at the top of your outline in progress. Your thesis statement will likely be included in your essay as the last sentence of your introduction paragraph.

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3.4: Chapter Recap

If you have been following along with the approach this guidebook is providing for writing an essay, you should have the following content for your essay:

- Evidence that can be used in your essay
 - Ideas or points that each piece of evidence will support
 - A working thesis statement that represents the overall argument that each of your ideas will indeed support.
 - An outline in progress in which this content is organized in the manner that it will appear in the essay.
 - With this content pinned down and organized, we should be feeling on solid ground. There is still work to be done and the next step is developing the third major part of each paragraph which is our analysis for each paragraph.
-

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Chapter 4: Analysis

- [4.1: Context- Why Analysis is Important](#)
- [4.2: What is Analysis?](#)
- [4.3: Analysis in our Essays](#)
- [4.4: Developing Analysis pt. 1](#)
- [4.5: Developing Analysis pt. 2](#)
- [4.6: Including Analysis in our Outline](#)
- [4.7: Putting the Three Parts Together](#)
- [4.8: Chapter Recap](#)

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4.1: Context- Why Analysis is Important

Important!

Percentage wise, analysis will make up the bulk of your essay. Remember, we only write one introduction and one conclusion. We write several body paragraphs. It can be as few as one or as many as a million, depending on how long our essay is supposed to be. This is to say that the body paragraphs make up the bulk of our paper. They each should have three major parts:

1. The topic sentence
2. The example or piece of evidence
3. The analysis

The topic sentence is brief; usually just one sentence that introduces the point we want to make in the paragraph. The example/evidence also doesn't need to be too long; just enough information to support what is said in the topic sentence. Our analysis, however, should explain our points in detail and, therefore, will make up the bulk of our body paragraphs.

To put it another way: our body paragraphs make up the bulk of our paper, and our analysis makes up the bulk of our body paragraphs. Therefore, the analysis in our body paragraphs is the most prominent part of our essay.

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4.2: What is Analysis?

Analysis can be defined...

...as a detailed examination of a thing and its parts. When we analyze something, we ask the following:

- What am I analyzing and what is its purpose?
- How well is this thing I am analyzing fulfilling its purpose?
- What are the different parts, components, and elements of this thing I am analyzing?
- How is each component contributing to the success or failure of this thing in fulfilling its purpose?

Both physical things like tools and equipment can be analyzed, as well as non-physical things like ideas, policies, and speeches. Virtually, anything that has a purpose can be analyzed.

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4.3: Analysis in our Essays

In our essays...

Analysis is the third major part of a body paragraph. It begins after you have delivered the example or piece of evidence in the paragraph. Every body paragraph should end with analysis. The analysis in a body paragraphs should endeavor to explain:

1. How the evidence or example used in the body paragraph supports the point we are making.
2. How the point we are making in a body paragraph supports the thesis statement for our paper.

Note that...

Analysis should begin immediately following the example or piece of evidence provided in a body paragraph. Also, note that analysis should work to explain HOW or WHY evidence supports a point and HOW or WHY a point supports the paper's thesis statement. The imperative here is that we are trying to explain how our ideas work or how we developed them in some detail.

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4.4: Developing Analysis pt. 1

Analysis in Practice

Let's keep the role of analysis in mind while looking at the prompt question (I think it is a good idea to continuously refer to the question on the prompt throughout the essay writing process). Let's also look at our thesis statement as well as one point and its supporting evidence for the sample we have been developing.

Prompt Task/Question:

- "Write an essay in which you discuss what you believe is the role and limitations of the U.S. government in fighting climate change."

Our thesis statement:

- "The U.S. government is able to implement policies that can reduce the impact of climate change on our planet."

Point/Topic Sentence #1:

- "The U.S. Government can play a role in the fight against climate change by implementing cap and trade policies that will lower emissions nationwide."

Example/Evidence:

- "...cap and trade programs ensure emissions in a city or country do not exceed a designated limit. Today, thirteen U.S. states, China, Mexico, and every country in the European Union have implemented cap and trade systems...In 2013, California launched one of the United States' first cap and trade programs. As a result, the state's emissions fell by 10 percent between 2013 and 2018."

Digging In...

In this paragraph, our analysis will begin immediately following the evidence above and will, *first*, explain how the evidence supports the point being made and, *second*, how the point being made supports the thesis statement. I think a good way to start developing analysis is to make a bullet list of how the evidence supports the point being made; what do you want to touch on in this regard? This may require looking closely at the evidence you chose. Looking at the evidence above, I want to touch on the following:

- 13 U.S. states, as well as every country in the European Union have done this, which shows it is possible; the government can implement it.
- California lowering emissions by 10% as a result shows that it can work to lower emissions; it does seem to work.

Those are two great bullet points that show both that it is something that is possible for our government to do and that the policy can indeed work to lower emissions. Now, let's consider how this point supports the overall thesis statement by making additional bullet points.

- This action is within the role the U.S. government plays in our lives.
- This action can be a helpful tool in the fight against climate change.

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4.5: Developing Analysis pt. 2

Keep Digging!

- 13 U.S. states, as well as every country in the European Union have done this, which shows it is possible; the government can implement it.
- California lowering emissions by 10% as a result shows that it can work to lower emissions; it does seem to work.
- This action is within the role the U.S. government plays in our lives.
- This action can be a helpful tool in the fight against climate change.

The above bullet points we developed on the previous page. They represent the connections we want to try and make in the analysis portion of this paragraph. Now, let's use those bullet points to develop some analysis. Below, I have written analysis for this body paragraph in detail using the details I wanted to touch on in the above bullet points.

Notice how the analysis below begins by explaining how the **evidence supports the point/topic sentence** and ends by explaining how the **point/topic sentence supports the thesis statement**.

Also notice that the language used **addresses the prompt question directly** as well as **references phrases** in the thesis statement, topic sentence, and example/evidence in order to make all the major parts of the essay **feel connected**.

Notice the explicit connections

I have highlighted this connective language in bold.

- “The fact that **13 states and the European Union** have done this shows it is possible for the **government to implement cap and trade policies nationwide**. Not only have other wealthy democracies done this, but states in our own country have also done it, proving it is within our **government's abilities**. Additionally, because of the success **California** has had in **lowering emissions by 10%** as a result of **cap and trade** we know that it is a policy that can indeed work to lower the amount of greenhouse gases entering our skies. **Implementing** such a **policy** is fully within **the role of the U.S. Government** which we can see from the presence of such **policies** in the governments of our own states and countries with similar political systems as ours. Therefore, this **policy** can be a helpful tool in the **fight against climate change** that the **U.S. government** can have a **role in implementing**.”

Look over the prompt question, thesis statement, topic sentence, and example/evidence on the previous page. Read the language in each closely. Then, look at the analysis above and carefully consider how it uses the same language. Do you see how it can make the ideas feel more detailed and connected?

Using "Cause and Effect" Language

Now, I am going to post the analysis one more time. This time, I am going to put in bold “cause and effect language”. These are words and phrases that show how I indeed came up with my idea based on the evidence I found and how my idea supports my overall argument thus satisfying the analytical process of EXPLAINING how something does indeed work.

“The fact that 13 states and the European Union have done this **shows it is possible** for the U.S. government to implement cap and trade policies nationwide. Not only have other wealthy democracies done this, but states in our own country have also done it, **proving it is** within our government's abilities. **Because of** the success California has had in lowering emissions by 10% **as a result** of cap and trade **we know** it is a policy that can indeed **work to** lower the amount of greenhouse gases entering our skies. Implementing such a policy is fully within the role of the U.S. Government **as noticed** from the presence of such policies in the governments of our own states and countries with similar political systems as ours. **Therefore**, this policy can be a helpful tool in the fight against climate change that the U.S. government can have a role in implementing

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4.6: Including Analysis in our Outline

Filling the Outline in with Analysis

When we have an analysis developed for each body paragraph, or even simply bullet points, we can include that analysis in our outline. Consider the sample below:

Body Paragraph #1

- **Topic sentence**—"The government can implement cap and trade policies to lower emissions and promote clean energy."
- **Example/Evidence**—"...cap and trade programs ensure emissions in a city or country do not exceed a designated limit. Today, thirteen U.S. states, China, Mexico, and every country in the European Union have implemented cap and trade systems...In 2013, California launched one of the United States' first cap and trade programs. As a result, the state's emissions fell by 10 percent between 2013 and 2018."
- **Analysis**—"The fact that 13 states and the European Union have done this shows it is possible for the U.S. government to implement cap and trade policies nationwide. Not only have other wealthy democracies done this, but states in our own country have also done it, proving it is within our government's abilities. Because of the success California has had in lowering emissions by 10% as a result of cap and trade we know it is a policy that can indeed work to lower the amount of greenhouse gases entering our skies. Implementing such a policy is fully within the role of the U.S. Government as noticed from the presence of such policies in the governments of our own states and countries with similar political systems as ours. Therefore, this policy can be a helpful tool in the fight against climate change that the U.S. government can have a role in implementing."

**Note, if you don't have your analysis fully developed, you can use a bulleted list of the connections you want to make to fill in the analysis portion of your outline.

Success is now imminent

If we can have each body paragraph for our essay outlined in the same level of detail as the one above, drafting our essay should not give us any problems. All the content we need is developed and organized.

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4.7: Putting the Three Parts Together

Planning Pays!

Now that we have the three major parts of this body paragraph organized in an outline, we can confidently put it together in a body paragraph knowing that:

- Our paragraph is focused on one, and only one, point.
- The point our paragraph is focused on does support our thesis statement.
- The point our paragraph is focused on is introduced with a “topic sentence.”
- The point/topic sentence is supported by an appropriate example or piece of evidence
- We have written analysis that explains how the evidence supports our point and that also explains how our point supports our thesis statement.
- Our paragraph is organized in the way that is expected i.e., the topic sentence, example/evidence, and analysis appear in that order.

Consider how the body paragraph below reads and how the outline set us up for success.

A developed body paragraph:

The U.S. government can play a role in the fight against climate change by implementing cap and trade policies that will lower emissions nationwide. “...cap and trade programs ensure emissions in a city or country do not exceed a designated limit. Today, thirteen U.S. states, China, Mexico, and every country in the European Union have implemented cap and trade systems...In 2013, California launched one of the United States’ first cap and trade programs. As a result, the state’s emissions fell by 10 percent between 2013 and 2018.” “The fact that 13 states and the European Union have done this shows it is possible for the U.S. government to implement cap and trade policies nationwide. Not only have other wealthy democracies done this, but states in our own country have also done it, proving it is within our government’s abilities. Because of the success California has had in lowering emissions by 10% as a result of cap and trade we know it is a policy that can indeed work to lower the amount of greenhouse gases entering our skies. Implementing such a policy is fully within the role of the U.S. Government as noticed from the presence of such policies in the governments of our own states and countries with similar political systems as ours. Therefore, this policy can be a helpful tool in the fight against climate change that the U.S. government can have a role in implementing.”

Too easy!

With enough detail in your outline, you can simply copy what you have in the outline and paste it onto a separate document as a means of composing your essay. Remember, I encourage outlining body paragraphs as they are:

- The bulk of your essay.
- Require a heightened level of focus and organization.
- Explain the ideas that support your thesis statement.

Introduction paragraphs and conclusion paragraphs are not written to explain ideas in detail with the same level of focus and organization, therefore, I do not focus on them in an outline.

Moving Forward...

When you feel like you understand analysis and how it works in our body paragraphs, I encourage you to finish filling out your outline by adding analysis for each body paragraph in as much detail as you can. If nothing else, at least try to get some bullet points in the analysis section of your outline. Don’t forget to consider the language used in the prompt question, your thesis statement, the topic sentence, and example/evidence to help you develop your analysis and ensure your ideas feel connected.

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4.8: Chapter Recap

Upon reading this chapter you should feel confident:

- Understanding the nuances of an essay prompt
 - Finding meaningful content in materials provided by your instructor and/or found doing your own research that is relevant to the essay prompt
 - Developing ideas based on the content you found.
 - Developing a thesis statement based on the ideas you want to write about
 - Writing analysis for each idea that explains how the evidence that corresponds to the idea does indeed support it and how the idea does indeed support your thesis statement.
 - Organizing these ideas and the examples/evidence you found into an outline.
 - Using a well detailed outline to compose a strong, focused, and organized body paragraph.
-

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Chapter 5: Minor Parts of the Body Paragraph

[5.1: Meet the Minor Parts of a Body Paragraph](#)

[5.2: Context and Background Information](#)

[5.3: Signal Phrase and In text Citations](#)

[5.4: Chapter Recap](#)

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5.1: Meet the Minor Parts of a Body Paragraph

Remember....

As mentioned, body paragraphs, which make up the bulk of our essay, have three major parts:

- the topic sentence, which introduces the point we want to make
- the example/evidence which shows the point is valid
- analysis that explains how the example/evidence shows our point is valid and that also explains how the point of the paragraph supports the paper's overall thesis statement.

Prioritize understanding these three major parts. If you have a good handle on them, odds are you will do fine on your papers.

Additionally....

That being said, there are a few smaller parts of the body paragraph that can help your paper's flow, give context to your ideas, and help to uplift the quality of your examples/evidence.

These "minor" parts of the body paragraph are:

- context/background information
- signal phrases
- in-text citations

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5.2: Context and Background Information

Minor yet Mighty!

Context/background information can help give clarity to your topic sentence and add credibility to your example/evidence. It also helps the flow of your paper so that your evidence doesn't feel like it is coming out of nowhere. I encourage students to offer context and background information after they have shared their topic sentence and before they offer their example/evidence.

Consider this example:

Topic Sentence: *The government can implement cap and trade policies to lower emissions and promote clean energy.*

Background/Context: *Cap and trade is a system that sets a limit on emissions and allows companies to buy and sell allowances for their share of that limit. This market-based approach has been used by several U.S. states and other countries.*

Now, consider how it all flows together:

"The government can implement cap and trade policies to lower emissions and promote clean energy. Cap and trade is a system that sets a limit on emissions and allows companies to buy and sell allowances for their share of that limit. This market-based approach has been used by several U.S. states and other countries. "...cap and trade programs ensure emissions in a city or country do not exceed a designated limit. Today, thirteen U.S. states, China, Mexico, and every country in the European Union have implemented cap and trade systems...In 2013, California launched one of the United States' first cap and trade programs. As a result, the state's emissions fell by 10 percent between 2013 and 2018."

Compare and Contrast

Consider that, compared to a body paragraph that does not offer context or background information after the topic sentence:

"The government can implement cap and trade policies to lower emissions and promote clean energy. "...cap and trade programs ensure emissions in a city or country do not exceed a designated limit. Today, thirteen U.S. states, China, Mexico, and every country in the European Union have implemented cap and trade systems...In 2013, California launched one of the United States' first cap and trade programs. As a result, the state's emissions fell by 10 percent between 2013 and 2018."

Notice how the context/background helps the paper flow and clarifies what cap and trade is so the reader can absorb the example/evidence with a clear understanding of the point being made.

Strategies

Here is possible content that I think makes for good context/background information:

- define terms in the topic sentence or example/evidence that might not be known to the reader
- give background information on a concept or entity in the topic sentence or example/evidence that might not be known to the reader
- provide a brief summary of the material that the example/evidence is coming from
- provide a brief summary of who the author of said materials is and what their credentials are
- give context as to what is happening or what is being discussed in the material during the part in which the example/evidence has been pulled from

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5.3: Signal Phrase and In text Citations

Signal Phrase

A signal phrase introduces the example/evidence you are sharing in a body paragraph. It will come after the context/background information in the paragraph. It tells the reader where the information you are sharing came from and also "signals" that the language in your paper is about to change from yours to someone else's. A signal phrase should be provided right before the example/evidence is shared.

Evidence shared without a signal phrase:

"...cap and trade programs ensure emissions..."

Evidence shared with a signal phrase:

According to a report from the Council on Foreign Relations, "cap and trade programs ensure emissions in a city or country do not exceed a designated limit..."

Notice how the signal phrase:

- Credits the source
- Prepares the reader for what's coming
- Integrates smoothly into your sentence

Let's look at it all together using the same sample from the previous part of this chapter:

"The government can implement cap and trade policies to lower emissions and promote clean energy. Cap and trade is a system that sets a limit on emissions and allows companies to buy and sell allowances for their share of that limit. This market-based approach has been used by several U.S. states and other countries. According to a report from the Council on Foreign Relations, "...cap and trade programs ensure emissions in a city or country do not exceed a designated limit. Today, thirteen U.S. states, China, Mexico, and every country in the European Union have implemented cap and trade systems...In 2013, California launched one of the United States' first cap and trade programs. As a result, the state's emissions fell by 10 percent between 2013 and 2018."

Here is the same paragraph without the context/background information and without the signal phrase before a quote:

"The government can implement cap and trade policies to lower emissions and promote clean energy. "...cap and trade programs ensure emissions in a city or country do not exceed a designated limit. Today, thirteen U.S. states, China, Mexico, and every country in the European Union have implemented cap and trade systems...In 2013, California launched one of the United States' first cap and trade programs. As a result, the state's emissions fell by 10 percent between 2013 and 2018."

Notice how these additional parts of the body paragraph, although minor, enhance the flow and credibility of the paper significantly.

Examples of Signal Phrases:

- According to....
- Consider the following information from....
- The author Jane Doe in her article titled____writes....
- It has been reported in_____that....

Many more examples can be found online.

In-text Citation

The final piece to what we are adding, and perhaps most important, is an "in-text citation".

Although we are letting the reader know where our evidence is coming from via a signal phrase, many teachers also want to see an "in-text citation" that lets them know more about the source we used.

An in-text citation is a small amount of information we include after the example or evidence we provide. It credits the source we used and also gives information that allows readers to find the source on our works cited page. Usually, we don't include the same information from our signal phrase in our in-text citation. That being said, an author's last name usually will suffice as an in-text citation. If the author's name is not provided in your source, then you can use a brief word or phrase from the title of the source you used.

Consider the example below:

"The government can implement cap and trade policies to lower emissions and promote clean energy. Cap and trade is a system that sets a limit on emissions and allows companies to buy and sell allowances for their share of that limit. This market-based approach has been used by several U.S. states and other countries. According to a report from the Council on Foreign Relations, "...cap and trade programs ensure emissions in a city or country do not exceed a designated limit. Today, thirteen U.S. states, China, Mexico, and every country in the European Union have implemented cap and trade systems...In 2013, California launched one of the United States' first cap and trade programs. As a result, the state's emissions fell by 10 percent between 2013 and 2018" (Governments Combat).

In this case, the article does not have an author's name provided, and we already used Council of Foreign Relations in our signal phrase. The title of the article is "How Do Governments Combat Climate Change?" Therefore, I used the phrase "Governments Combat" for my in-text citation.

Every piece of evidence you provide should be followed by an in-text citation.

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5.4: Chapter Recap

Ok, so...

- We have spend a lot of time talking about body paragraphs.
- That is because body paragraphs make up the bulk of your essay.
- In our body paragraphs, we write about our ideas, one idea at a time.
- We stay focused by organizing each body paragraph into three major parts.
- Additionally, there are two minor parts of a body paragraph we can include that are very useful.

Hopefully....

- The process I am trying to convey makes sense. If so, you should feel comfortable with the following:
- Examining readings and other materials for information that is relevant to the task on your essay prompt.
- Developing ideas based on that information that you can write about in your essay.
- Keeping your ideas, evidence, and analysis organized in an outline.
- Coming up with a thesis statement.
- Using your well detailed outline to create a draft of your body paragraphs in progress.
- Adding context and signal phrases to each body paragraph.

If Not...

- I encourage you to review the process until it does make sense.
- Remember, there is a glossary that explains the termonology I am using if needed.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Chapter 6: The Introduction Paragraph

- [6.1: Why not Write the Intro First?](#)
- [6.2: What is an Introduction Paragraph?](#)
- [6.3: The General to Specific Method](#)
- [6.4: Other Methods](#)
- [6.5: Introduction Chapter Recap](#)

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6.1: Why not Write the Intro First?

It can wait

As mentioned, I encourage students to resist the urge to write an introduction as the first step in developing their essays.

Although our essays will begin with an introduction, I usually wait to write them until I have my body paragraphs composed first. This is because, again, body paragraphs make up the bulk of our essay and they also require a heightened level of focus, structure, and organization as each body paragraph should endeavor to explain one of our ideas in detail. Introductions paragraphs are not meant to explain specific ideas in detail. We don't need to provide evidence in our introductions, nor do we need to do any analysis. All we have to do in our introduction is introduce to the reader some of the things we will be writing about.

Additionally, I prefer writing an introduction when I have an understanding of everything that is going to be included in my paper i.e. all my points, the evidence I am going to use, and my reasoning in each paragraph. Understanding these things will help me think of what I want to include in my introduction and how I want to present it for the reader. Before getting too far ahead, let's consider the role of an introduction paragraph.

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6.2: What is an Introduction Paragraph?

An introduction paragraph....

An introduction paragraph simply introduces the subject of your essay to the reader. In the case of the sample essay I have been using in this guidebook, the subject would be climate change, or, more specifically, what the role and limitations are of the U.S. government in fighting climate change.

There are a variety of ways this subject can be introduced, including but not limited to:

- Giving an overview of why this has become an issue in the first place
- Explaining the history of the issue
- Offering general information and ruminations about governments' role in solving problems.
- Telling or relaying to the reader a compelling story related to the issue.
- Summarizing an article that covers the issue.

Keep in mind that in our introduction paragraphs, we are not yet making, supporting, or explaining any points or positions we have related to the subject of the essay. All that work happens in our body paragraphs. In our introduction, we don't have to do anything more than introduce the subject of our essay, mention some of the sources we will be citing from, and end with our thesis statement. We don't have to explain our thesis statement or compose any reasoning for any of our opinions. Again, all that work is done in the body paragraphs for the essay unless otherwise specified by your teacher.

With all that said, what are some ways we can write an introduction?

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6.3: The General to Specific Method

General to Specific

A lot of teachers will instruct their students to write an introduction paragraph using a model I refer to as “**General to Specific**”. I call it this because the model typically guides students through a process of writing generally about the subject of their essay and ultimately getting more specific before ending the introduction with their thesis statement, which would be the most specific idea shared in their introduction paragraph.

Many teachers encourage their students to begin this process with a “**hook**”: a captivating statement that will draw the reader’s attention. The hook can present a compelling statistic, a powerful image, a clever turn of phrase, among other things.

I don’t want to dissuade students from using a hook if it is something they are drawn to however, I do not require or even encourage my students to use a hook if they don’t want to. In my opinion, **starting an introduction with something very general about the subject of your essay** is perfectly acceptable.

- Hook—“Each year, the United States experiences more billion-dollar climate disasters than the year before, from hurricanes to wildfires.”
- General Statement—“Climate change is an issue that many people have debated for a long time.”

To me, both of these would be an acceptable first sentence to an introduction. But we need more than one sentence in our introduction. So, where do we go from here?

I think **background information** is always a good bet, regardless of what strategy you decide on for writing your introduction. If you do choose to go “general to specific,” background information can be especially useful. Maybe, in this case, define what is meant by climate change.

- “Everyone agrees that the Earth is getting warmer. Some people believe that this warming is influenced by human beings. Some people believe that the warming of the planet is causing more severe weather and disasters. Others believe that the warming planet is not something that humans cause or should concern ourselves with.”

Again, the writing here is simply introducing the subject of the essay. Perhaps it is getting a bit more specific because it is starting to allude to a question regarding whether or not humans should concern themselves and act to address the issue.

In the process of writing an introduction that moves from “general to specific”, I think it is useful to include a moment in your writing where things feel like they are dramatically shifting from an overview to a specific idea or argument. I refer to this part of the introduction as “**the turn**”.

“Turning” from general to specific can be done in several different ways. I believe the most user-friendly approach is to offer a “rhetorical question”—a question that is supposed to be pondered rather than answered.

- “But, what is the government’s role in the face of such a situation? Is the cost of inaction greater than the cost of action, or would their effort to fight climate change result in more problems than we are actually faced with?”

Now, our introduction feels like it is starting to focus on a specific issue or question related to the broader subject.

From here, I think **introducing some of the sources** you will be quoting from is an effective way to lead into your thesis statement.

- “After reading articles found on the Council on Foreign Relations website, material in the Wall Street Journal, and other compelling sources, it has become clear to me that there are reasonable measures the U.S. government can take to try to reduce the impact of climate change.”

Now, I am set up to end the introduction with my **thesis statement** if and when I have one ready. As of now, my thesis statement is:

- “The U.S. government is able to implement policies that can reduce the impact of climate change on our planet.”

Let’s look at how it all looks together. Remember, this sample introduction follows the “General to Specific” method.

“Climate change is an issue that many people have debated over for a long time. Everyone agrees that the Earth is getting warmer. Some people believe that this warming is influenced by human beings. Some people believe that the warming of the planet is causing more severe weather and disasters. Others believe that the warming planet is not something that humans cause or should concern ourselves with. But, what is the government’s role in the face of such a situation? Is the cost of inaction greater than the cost of action or would their effort to fight climate change result in more problems than we are actually faced with? After reading

articles found on the Council of Foreign Relations website, material in the Wall Street Journal, and other compelling sources, it has become clear to me that there are reasonable measures the U.S. government can take to try to reduce the impact of climate change. The U.S. government is able to implement policies that can reduce the impact of climate change on our planet.”

If this is a method that feels approachable to you, remember the various parts that help the paragraph move from general to specific:

- Hook or general information
- Background information
- The “turn”
- Mention some sources
- End with thesis statement

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6.4: Other Methods

But wait, there's more!

Although the "general to specific" method of writing an introduction might be the most commonly taught and therefore most commonly applied method for writing an introduction. There are several other methods that can help you introduce the subject of your essay to the reader before offering your thesis statement and body paragraphs. Remember, it is the body paragraphs that require focus, rigor, organization, and structure. With the introduction and conclusion, you have more freedom. You are not required to explain any of your ideas. Just introduce the subject of the essay, maybe mention some of the sources you used, and end by sharing your thesis statement. With that said, here are some other methods for writing an introduction.

1. Summarize a Compelling Source

This method involves drawing the reader in by summarizing a particularly striking or relevant source, such as an article, research study, or interview, that directly relates to your essay topic. This approach immediately provides credibility and context, showing that you've done your research.

2. Share a Personal Story

This approach brings a more human touch to the introduction by using a personal story or anecdote related to the topic. Personal stories can draw readers in emotionally and make the issue feel more relatable and immediate.

3. Offer a Hypothetical Situation

A hypothetical situation invites the reader to imagine a scenario related to the issue at hand. This approach can be used to challenge assumptions or illustrate the potential consequences of ignoring the issue.

4. Explain the Historical Background or Why It Is an Issue

This method works by providing a brief historical overview of the issue at hand, giving context to why the issue is significant today. It's useful for setting up a long-standing problem that requires a solution or deeper analysis.

Remember...

Whatever approach you choose, remember to always include your thesis statement as the last sentence of your introduction as a rule of thumb. Additionally, even if you chose one of the four methods provided on this page, you can still include things like rhetorical questions and mention some of the sources you will be quoting from to add detail to your introduction.

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6.5: Introduction Chapter Recap

Well, that was quick

- Yes, as I had mentioned, the introduction paragraph is not so insurmountable.
- You have freedom to approach it in a variety of ways.
- You are not confined to write about a single idea in detail (as you are with body paragraphs)
- This is why it can wait.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Chapter 7: Different Ways of Writing a Conclusion

[7.1: What is a Conclusion Paragraph](#)

[7.2: Different Ways of Writing a Conclusion](#)

[7.3: Chapter Recap](#)

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7.1: What is a Conclusion Paragraph

This is the end!

The conclusion paragraph is the final paragraph in your essay. Like the introduction, we do not have to worry about explaining any ideas in the conclusion paragraph, and therefore have some freedom to write without too much structure. All our conclusion needs to do is give a sense of closure—something that tells the reader, “*I’m done making my argument.*” That’s the job of the conclusion paragraph. It’s not about introducing new ideas or rewriting your entire essay in different words. Instead, it’s your chance to gently wrap things up, remind your reader why your ideas matter, and leave them with something to think about.

It is often taught to write a conclusion by summarizing your overall argument and all the points you made. That is a totally viable approach, although, in my experience, many students feel stifled and uninspired trying to write a conclusion this way. They often tell me it feels forced and repetitive. I don’t disagree.

In the next part of this chapter, I have made a list of different ways you can write a conclusion. I hope some of them work for you. Feel free to mix, match, and modify, if needed.

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7.2: Different Ways of Writing a Conclusion

Summarize the Idea and Main Points of your Essay:

This is what most of us learned how to do in high school. For some of us it works well but often people feel like they are being too repetitive.

What can we learn from your essay?

Are there lessons in your essay that would be valuable for people to understand? If your essay is about a character in literature, for example, what can we learn from that character? If it is about a debate, what can we learn from understanding the debate?

Explain or describe two things you learned about the subject of your essay during the writing process.

Writing a conclusion in this way can give a sense of closure by indicating to the reader that there is still much to read, learn, and discuss regarding the subject and topics that you chose to write about for the essay.

Pan to the Horizon:

Now that the reader has acquired knowledge gain from reading your essay in what ways would you advise them to view the world.

Offer a Solution:

If your paper is focused on something particularly problematic, you can conclude your essay by proposing solutions to the problem and why you think the solutions will work.

Secondary Thesis:

Identify a commonality between all of your topics and consider a secondary thesis on what unites them. Is there a larger message in your paper about what all these topics say about us as humans as well as the world or society at large? What are the implications of the subject, topics, and ideas you wrote about?

Mention Additional Points Not Expanded on in the Essay

Write about any additional points that can prove your thesis is valid that you did not get to elaborate on in body paragraphs.

Call to Action

Encourage people be active and take measures that can help solve, mitigate, or reverse the problem. Try to be specific as to what actions they can take in everyday life as well as things that might be more extraordinary.

Find Common Ground

If the essay is addressing a polarizing or contested social, political, economic, or philosophical issue try to put forth a solution or middle ground that can satisfy people on different sides of the issue.

Qualify your argument

Offer a sense of closure to your paper by acknowledging the limitations of your argument. There are always exceptions to every rule so what are some areas where your argument may fall short or not be realized in the way you have explained in the essay. End the conclusion by reassuring the reader that even with its limitations, your argument is still more valid and worth adopting then not.

A Glimpse of the Future

Offer some perspective or insight as to how your argument will be relative in the future. Will the grounds of the argument change? Will it be more relevant? Will the way people talk or think about the subject of your essay change and if so will your argument have to change with it?

A light at the end of the tunnel

Is there anything to be hopeful about regarding the subject of your essay? Are there examples of resilience and evolution through difficult situations?

Why its important

Explain why it is important for people to care, consider, or think critically about the subject of your essay. Additionally, can you explain why it is important to take the stance you chose to champion in the essay?

Symbolism and Significance

What is the broader symbolism or significance of your paper? What universal implications exist within the topics, points, and evidence you provided? How does the content of your essay apply to people more broadly? What does it say about human beings and the world we live in?

Closing Argument

Pretend you are an attorney making your closing argument. What is your final plea for people to take your side in this argument? Why will it make the world a better place? What is at stake if people do not take your side?

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7.3: Chapter Recap

If nothing else...

- I hope you see how breezy introductions and conclusions can be.
 - Intros simply introduce the subject of your essay and share your overall argument.
 - Conclusions simply offer a sense of closure.
 - No in depth explanation of ideas or analysis is needed.
 - Time focusing on your body paragraphs is time well spent.
 - Prioritize the body of your essay!
-

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Chapter 8: Counter Arguments and Rebuttals

[8.1: What is a Counterargument and Rebuttal? \(aka Naysater Paragraph\)](#)

[8.2: Developing your Counterargument and Rebuttal](#)

[8.3: Chapter Recap](#)

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8.1: What is a Counterargument and Rebuttal? (aka Naysater Paragraph)

Ok, so there is some more

A counterargument and rebuttal is one or more paragraphs that take the time to introduce points, ideas, information, etc. that runs contrary to the argument you have been developing in your paper before explaining why those points, ideas, information, etc. are ultimately short-sighted, incorrect, or otherwise do not provide enough reason for an audience not to take your side in the argument.

Counterarguments and rebuttals can also go by the names:

- Concession and refutation
- Counterclaim and rebuttal
- Acknowledgment and response
- Naysayer paragraph

It is not uncommon for these paragraphs to be required in academic writing and, even if not, they can be good ways to help you meet the page limit or word count for longer papers.

They can be written as one paragraph that includes both the counterclaim and the rebuttal OR a paragraph can be written that explains the counterclaim in more detail, and then a separate paragraph can explain the rebuttal in more detail.

Typically, only one counterclaim and rebuttal is offered, although it is possible to write more than one and sometimes even required.

Some essays might ask for an alternating series of counterclaims and rebuttals for the body of the essay.

Again, typically only one is required and it is usually included as the final body paragraph(s) before the conclusion unless otherwise stated on the essay prompt.

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8.2: Developing your Counterargument and Rebuttal

Overview

To write a counterargument and rebuttal, you will simply follow the same organizational structure as any other body paragraph:

- topic sentence
- example/evidence
- analysis

What is different is that your topic sentence will provide a point that DOES NOT support your thesis statement and instead runs contrary to the argument shared in your thesis statement.

Using the same hypothetical essay I have been for this guidebook, let's say my thesis statement is:

- "The U.S. government is able to implement policies that can reduce the impact of climate change on our planet."

All of the points I have made in my body paragraphs so far support this overall argument however, the prompt is asking for a counterargument and rebuttal.

Step One

In my notes, I remember copying down some information that addressed the limitations of government in addressing climate change, specifically when it came to implementing policies.

If I didn't have this information in my notes, I would try to do some research to see what people on the opposite side of this debate are saying. I would try to work with a librarian to help me find what I needed.

In this case, I have this quote:

- *"The whole point of cap and trade is to hike the price of electricity and gas so that Americans will use less. These higher prices will show up not just in electricity bills or at the gas station but in every manufactured good, from food to cars. Consumers will cut back on spending, which in turn will cut back on production, which results in fewer jobs created or higher unemployment."*

Similar to what I did at the beginning of the essay writing process, I am going to look at this quote and ask myself what it is telling me, not about what the government's role is, but what the government's limitations are since that is a point that would run contrary to my thesis statement.

Looking at the quote, it is implying that cap and trade policies will increase gas and electricity bills, which will, in turn, impact the spending power Americans have, which will, in turn, impact production, which will, in turn, result in fewer jobs and higher unemployment.

Step Two

Now, your instinct might be to disagree since you are writing a paper that is trying to prove an argument on the other side of this debate. Make note of what you might want to say in your rebuttal but resist your instinct to dismiss this quote and its implications. Instead, try to develop a topic sentence that would work to share a point that this quote is supporting.

For example:

- "Some people argue that the government should be limited in their authority to implement policies like cap and trade, which would make gas and electricity prices higher, because it would impact production and employment."

Notice how this topic sentence introduces or acknowledges a point that runs contrary to the argument you have been making in your paper. This is how we want our counterargument paragraph to start.

Step Three

Next, I encourage students to continue writing the paragraph as if they are temporarily taking this position. Give context/background information after the topic sentence and include a quote that either shows proof that the topic sentence has some truth to it OR at least shows that there are people out there making the point shared in the topic sentence. Consider how we continue:

- "Some people argue that the government should be limited in their authority to implement policies like cap and trade, which would make gas and electricity prices higher, because it would impact production and employment." (topic sentence)

- "Their concern is that higher energy costs could burden both businesses and consumers, slowing the economy and leading to job losses." (context/background information)
- As one critic explains, *"The whole point of cap and trade is to hike the price of electricity and gas so that Americans will use less. These higher prices will show up not just in electricity bills or at the gas station but in every manufactured good, from food to cars. Consumers will cut back on spending, which in turn will cut back on production, which results in fewer jobs created or higher unemployment."* (example/evidence with signal phrase)

Step Four

The next part of any body paragraph, of course, is your analysis. In a counterargument and rebuttal paragraph, this is typically where your rebuttal comes in. In other words, you typically use the analysis of a counterclaim and rebuttal paragraph to explain why the point you shared in the topic sentence and the evidence provided to support it is ultimately weak, shortsighted, or otherwise not enough for readers to not take your position.

Consider what follows:

"This argument plays into a common fear: that environmental policies hurt economic growth. However, this viewpoint is shortsighted because it focuses only on immediate costs and ignores the long-term economic and environmental benefits of reducing emissions. In reality, cap and trade programs have been shown to incentivize innovation, create new green jobs, and improve public health by reducing pollution. For example, when California implemented a cap and trade system, the state saw both a drop in emissions and an increase in clean energy investments—without stalling economic growth. While there may be short-term adjustments, limiting government action based on fear of rising costs overlooks the broader and more sustainable benefits of transitioning to a cleaner economy. In the long run, the cost of inaction on climate change—ranging from disaster relief to healthcare—is far greater than the cost of adapting energy systems now."

How it looks altogether:

Some people argue that the government should be limited in their authority to implement policies like cap and trade, which would make gas and electricity prices higher because, it would impact production and employment. Their concern is that higher energy costs could burden both businesses and consumers, slowing the economy and leading to job losses. As one critic explains, *"The whole point of cap and trade is to hike the price of electricity and gas so that Americans will use less. These higher prices will show up not just in electricity bills or at the gas station but in every manufactured good, from food to cars. Consumers will cut back on spending, which in turn will cut back on production, which results in fewer jobs created or higher unemployment."* This argument plays into a common fear: that environmental policies hurt economic growth. However, this viewpoint is shortsighted because it focuses only on immediate costs and ignores the long-term economic and environmental benefits of reducing emissions. In reality, cap and trade programs have been shown to incentivize innovation, create new green jobs, and improve public health by reducing pollution. For example, when California implemented a cap and trade system, the state saw both a drop in emissions and an increase in clean energy investments—without stalling economic growth. While there may be short-term adjustments, limiting government action based on fear of rising costs overlooks the broader and more sustainable benefits of transitioning to a cleaner economy. In the long run, the cost of inaction on climate change—ranging from disaster relief to healthcare—is far greater than the cost of adapting energy systems now.

A few things to note:

- You may be asked to provide evidence that supports your rebuttal. You should be able to include it in your analysis.
- It is also possible, may even be required sometimes, to write one entire paragraph for the counterclaim and another entire paragraph for your rebuttal. If this happens, just use analysis in your counterclaim to explain the opposing position and evidence in more detail, like you would do for a body paragraph that supports your points and ideas, and then write a rebuttal that addresses the specific point and evidence in your counterclaim using the same structure you would for any other body paragraph.

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8.3: Chapter Recap

Recap

- Sometimes we are asked to write a counter argument and rebuttal in our essays.
- For this, we can follow the same steps as we do in our regular body paragraphs.
- The counterargument will introduce a point or idea that challenges your thesis.
- Evidence will support the counter argument.
- Analysis will refute the evidence and the counter argument.
- Done.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Chapter 9: Works Cited and References Page

[9.1: What is a Works Cited or References Page?](#)

[9.2: Basic Rules and Guidelines](#)

[9.3: Chapter Recap](#)

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9.1: What is a Works Cited or References Page?

After your paper...

A works cited (MLA) or references (APA) page is a list of all the sources you directly quoted, paraphrased, or referenced in your paper. It appears at the very end of your document, starting on a new page. Each entry gives full publication information about a source, so readers can locate it if they want to learn more.

In-text citations provided after the examples/evidence in your paper should provide a small amount of information that allows readers to find the entire citation on a works cited or references page.

Works cited or references pages provide a detailed summation of the publication information of a source. Do not list URL's, websites, links, or titles on a works cited page without any additional information.

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9.2: Basic Rules and Guidelines

What to keep in mind...

When formatting your Works Cited/References page:

1. Your works cited or references page begins on its own page and is titled "Works Cited" or "References." The title "Works Cited" or "References" will be centered at the top of the page.
2. Citations include a specific set of criteria provided in a specific order. For MLA, that order is as follows:
 - Author's Last Name, Author's First Name. "Title of Work". *Title of Larger Publication*. Version, Number, Publisher. Database Source was Found in. Publication Date or Date Accessed. URL.
 - APA is similar with the date coming after the title of the piece.

Include what you can and leave out what is not present or not applicable.

3. Alphabetize sources alphabetically by the author's last name. If there's no author, use the title or whatever information is present first in the citation.
4. Double-space everything: No extra spaces between entries.
5. Hanging indent: The first line of each entry is flush with the left margin; all following lines are indented.

Here is a sample:

Lee, Harper. *To Kill a Mockingbird*. Harper Perennial Modern Classics, 2006.

Nguyen, Viet Thanh. "War, Memory, and Identity." *American Literary History*, vol. 28, no. 2, 2016, pp. 345–367. *JSTOR*, doi:10.1093/alh/ajw021.

Pew Research Center. "Teens, Social Media & Technology 2022." *Pew Research Center: Internet, Science & Tech*, 10 Aug. 2022, www.pewresearch.org/internet/2022/08/10/teens-social-media-technology-2022/.

Advice...

If you are struggling with this, my advice is to work with a tutor or a librarian.

Note: Make things easier by keeping track of your sources from the beginning of the essay writing process.

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9.3: Chapter Recap

- Academic papers are almost always going to require a works cited or references page.
 - These pages list the sources used in your paper from which you included examples/evidence.
 - It is important that you document where exactly your information is coming from.
 - Formatting these pages correctly will have an impact on your final grade for the paper.
 - References and Works Cited are the same thing although have slight differences in how they are formatted.
 - Whether your paper needs a references or a works cited page will depend on what class the paper is for and/or what your teacher asks for.
 - There is a wealth of resources online and likely at your school that can help with these pages if needed.
-

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Chapter 10: In Summary

[10.1: In Summary](#)

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10.1: In Summary

That's all I got

I hope this guidebook will be useful to you. Again, I encourage you to go through this guidebook as a companion from the moment you are assigned an essay prompt and as you plan and write your paper. If I can provide a simple snapshot of what the whole process looks like from beginning to end, it would be something like this:

- understand the prompt
- find evidence and content from appropriate materials that address the question or task asked on the prompt
- think of ideas and opinions based on that content and evidence (1 idea=1 body paragraph)
- start organizing these ideas and information into an outline that prioritizes your body paragraphs
- compose a thesis statement that works as an overall argument that each idea you want to develop will support
- develop analysis for each idea, include it in your outline
- use your outline to compose body paragraphs; topic sentence, example/evidence, analysis
- write intro and conclusion (include thesis statement as the last sentence of the introduction)

I encourage you to write your essays step by step, looking over this guidebook frequently for direction. Also, working with tutors and using information available to you online, including videos, etc. is a great way to gain control and understanding of the essay writing process. There is a wealth of resources available that can help you write academic papers, so long as you take the time to understand how they are trying to instruct you and what the terminology they are using means. It can take time and a willingness to review the same things over and over, but once it all clicks, you will be surprised at how approachable your assigned essays can be.

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